

Outcomes of Democracy

Social Science — Civics • Chapter 5 • Chapter Summary & Study Guide for Daksh

Is democracy actually delivering on its promises? Does it give us better government, faster development, more equality, and greater dignity? This chapter takes stock — comparing democracies with dictatorships and asking honestly what democracy has achieved, where it has failed, and what we can reasonably expect of it.

How do we assess democracy?

Comparing democracies and non-democracies on outcomes is hard:

- Democracies vary enormously — comparing 'a democracy' to 'a non-democracy' is comparing apples to baskets of fruit.
- Outcomes depend on many factors — geography, history, economy, society — not just political system.
- Yet certain expectations are reasonable: a democracy should be expected to produce a government that is *accountable, responsive and legitimate*.

1. Accountable, responsive and legitimate government

Accountable means leaders answer to people through regular elections, parliamentary debates and public scrutiny. **Responsive** means government tries to attend to citizens' needs. **Legitimate** means people accept the government's right to rule.

- Democracies are slower at decision-making (consultations, debates) but better at **accepting consensus**.
- Democracies provide **regular, free and fair elections**; debate before decisions; citizens' right to know what's happening (RTI in India, 2005).
- Surveys (e.g. **South Asia Barometer 2008**) confirm — most people across South Asia, despite being unhappy with their leaders, believe democracy is the best form of government for their country.

2. Economic growth and development

Critics often say dictatorships grow faster (China vs India). The numbers show:

- Between 1950-2000, dictatorships grew slightly faster than democracies — but the difference is small (about 0.5%).
- But democracies handle economic crises and ensure long-term stability better.
- **Conclusion:** economic development depends on many factors (population size, global situation, cooperation from other countries, economic priorities). Democracies should not be rejected just on economic grounds — and we should expect democracies to perform **better** not worse on growth.

3. Reduction of inequality and poverty

Democracies are based on political equality — one person, one vote. But economic inequality has actually **increased** in many democracies, including India:

- A small section grows extraordinarily rich; a large section barely escapes poverty.
- Democracies have failed to reduce economic inequality decisively.
- Yet democratic processes (elections, RTI, courts, social movements, free media) *do* highlight inequality and pressure governments to redistribute (PDS, MGNREGA, education and health rights). The struggle continues.

4. Accommodation of social diversity

Democracies usually do better at handling differences — religious, ethnic, regional — because they are based on negotiation and dialogue. But this is not automatic: the example of **Belgium vs Sri Lanka** shows. Democracy succeeds when:

- **Majority and minority opinions** are not permanent; they keep shifting.

- Rule by majority does not become rule of one religious/social group — every social group has a chance to be in majority on some issue.
- Diversity is recognised and worked with — not denied.

5. Dignity and freedom of citizens

Democracy's most valuable outcome is hard to measure — it is **dignity and freedom**. Once granted, these expand. Examples:

- **Equal status and equal opportunity** for women — long-running struggle for property, education, equal pay, voting rights — bigger strides in democracies.
- **Castes and other groups** — Dalits and Adivasis can demand respect, contest elections, hold high office.
- **Citizens' rights** — voting, association, expression, dignified treatment by police and government — are deeply embedded in democratic culture.

Final reflection

Democracy's greatest virtue is that **complaints about democracy are themselves a sign of its success**. In a dictatorship, complaints can land you in jail. In a democracy, they fuel the next election, the next movement, the next reform. The very expectation that government must *do better* is democracy's lasting contribution to political life.

★ MUST-REMEMBER POINTS

- Expected outcomes: accountable + responsive + legitimate government; growth; reduced inequality; diversity accommodation; dignity & freedom.
- Right to Information Act (RTI) in India — 2005, makes government accountable.
- Democracies grow slightly slower than dictatorships, but more stable.
- Democracies handle social diversity better when minority/majority are not permanent groups.
- Democracies have given dignity to women, Dalits, marginalised — though inequality persists.
- South Asia Barometer 2008 — most people prefer democracy despite dissatisfaction with leaders.
- Democracy's success: complaints about it are openly aired — and lead to reform.

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